eyes scrutinizing me – or so I thought, I felt more at ease and soon started to hit the ball well. This time, Sir agreed to let me join the camp. I was delighted and I must say it was an opportunity that transformed my life.

The camp involved a session every morning and evening at Shivaji Park. I would practice between 7.30 am and 10.30 am in the morning. Then I'd come back in the afternoon and practice till late evening. The schedule was rigorous and I would be exhausted by the end of the day. Travelling to Shivaji Park took forty minutes from my house in Bandra and I had to catch an early morning bus to make it on time. For the first few days, Ajit accompanied me, to get me used to the routine. During the bus journeys, he would talk to me about the nuances of batting, and I always enjoyed these conversations a lot. In fact, the one thing that I have kept with me all my career is a note that Ajit gave me containing some thoughts about batting. It served as a very personal coaching manual.

- What was the opportunity that transformed the life of Sachin?
- What sort of conversations did Ajit and Sachin have while travelling?

As a child, I had only one set of cricket clothes and the routine was to wash them as soon as I'd returned from the morning session. While I had my lunch, the clothes would dry out in the sun and I would wear them again in the afternoon. The pattern was repeated in the evening so that I could use the same set of clothes the following morning. The system worked well – apart from my pockets. There was never quite enough time for the pockets to dry out completely, and for the entire duration of the camp I played with wet pockets. By the middle of the summer camp, Sir had started taking an active interest in my batting and at the end of the two months, informed Ajit that I had the potential to be a good cricketer if I practiced all year round. However, my school – the New English School in Bandra – did not have cricket facilities and Sir was keen for me to change schools if I wanted to pursue cricket seriously.

- What routine did Sachin follow in washing his clothes?
- What did Achrekar inform Ajit?

One evening, Sir called my father and put forward his suggestion. Ajit was in the room with my father at the time and they both accepted that it was necessary if cricket was to be my priority. My father sat me down and explained that while he did not have any objections to my changing schools, I should do so only if I was really serious about playing cricket.I assured him I was, and so it was agreed that I should move to Shardashram Vidhyamandir, where Achrekar Sir was the cricket coach. All my excess energies were getting channelled into cricket, which acted as a kind of safety valve. My father always said that all he wanted me to do was give it my best effort without worrying about the results.

- What was the suggestion given by Achrekar to Sachin's father?
- What acted as a safety valve?

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